

Chapter 17

The Memory

Elara's eyes opened suddenly.

Her heart was beating fast.

For a few seconds...

she simply stared at the ceiling.

Then the memory returned.

Roman.

The abandoned library.

His nervous expression.

His voice.

"I need to tell you something."

Elara slowly sat up.

Her breathing became uneven.

Another fragment followed.

Roman looking directly into her eyes.

His voice was softer than usual.

"Can I get one chance?"

Her eyes widened.

She placed a hand against her chest.

"Was that real?"

She got out of bed.

Her heart was still racing.

She walked to the table beside her bed, poured herself some water and drank it slowly.

Then she looked toward the window.

"Did Roman really say that to me?"

She closed her eyes.

The memory was still incomplete.

She could remember his voice.

His eyes.

The abandoned library.

But not what happened immediately afterward.

Elara took a deep breath.
"And if he really asked me..."
She swallowed.
"Does he still feel the same?"
Her heart beat faster again.
She immediately shook her head.
"No."
She whispered to herself,
"Calm down."
She sat on the edge of the bed.
She wasn't ready to tell anyone.
Not Ethan.
Not her parents.
And not Roman.
At least...
not yet.
For now, the memory would stay with her.
She picked up her phone.
Roman's name appeared on the screen.
Her thumb hovered over it.
Then she locked the phone.
"Later."
She placed it beside her.
But sleep didn't return.

Across the City

Roman sat in his office, still going through Noah's recovered files.
The relationship between Noah and Ethan was now confirmed.
Noah had planned to tell Elara on her birthday.
She had wanted it to be a surprise.
Roman closed the file.
There was still one question he couldn't answer.
What happened after that?

His phone vibrated.

His investigator had sent a message.

I found Ethan. He's meeting his father tonight.

Roman immediately replied.

Where?

A location arrived.

A private members' club on the outskirts of Frankfurt.

Roman looked at the message for a moment.

Then typed:

Stay close. Don't let them see you.

Later That Night

Ethan stumbled out of his car.

His movements were unsteady.

He had clearly been drinking.

His shirt was slightly torn, and a small amount of blood ran from a cut near his forehead.

He wiped it with the back of his hand and stared at the blood for a moment.

Then he walked inside the private club.

The main area was almost empty.

A few staff members moved quietly through the building.

Ethan's father was waiting in a secluded private lounge at the back.

He looked up as Ethan entered.

His expression immediately changed.

"What happened?"

Ethan closed the door behind him.

His father stood.

"Why are you bleeding?"

Ethan rubbed his forehead.

"There was an accident."

His father frowned.

"What accident?"

Ethan's words were slightly slurred.

"I was driving..."

He swallowed.

"There was a couple on the road."

His father stared at him.

"And?"

Ethan looked down.

"They're dead."

Silence filled the room.

His father's expression hardened.

"You're drunk."

"I know."

"What were you thinking?"

"I wasn't."

His father stepped closer.

"Do you even understand what you've done?"

Ethan said nothing.

His father looked at the blood on his forehead again.

Then his anger grew.

"And now there's another problem."

Ethan looked up.

"What?"

His father stared at him.

"You can't even stay out of trouble for one day."

Ethan lowered his eyes.

His father shook his head.

"How long are you going to keep doing this?"

"My influence won't save you every time."

Ethan remained silent.

His father took a breath.

Then his expression suddenly changed.

"Do you remember what happened three years ago?"

Ethan froze.

His father continued.

"Three years ago, you killed your girlfriend."

Ethan's face went pale.

"Dad..."

"It was an accident," Ethan whispered.

His father snapped.

"An accident?"

He stepped closer.

"Fine."

"Maybe the first part was an accident."

"But what did you do afterward?"

Ethan lowered his head.

"You ran."

"You left her there."

"You came to me instead of calling for help."

Ethan's eyes filled with fear.

"I was scared."

His father shook his head.

"And then you blamed Roman."

Ethan looked up.

His father continued.

"You moved the files."

"You twisted the investigation."

"You made everyone believe Roman was responsible."

"And when Roman disappeared..."

He paused.

"You let everyone believe he was dead."

Ethan's breathing became heavier.

"I thought he was dead."

His father stared at him.

"And now he's back."

Ethan looked away.

"I don't want him here."

His father's anger finally exploded.

He slapped Ethan across the face.

Ethan stumbled slightly.

"How long am I supposed to cover for you?"

His voice echoed through the room.

"How long?"

"I protected your name."

"I protected your reputation."

"I used my influence to keep the investigation from going where it should have."

"And now you're standing in front of me again because you've made another mess."

Ethan slowly dropped to his knees.

"Dad..."

His father stared down at him.

"Do you think my position will protect you forever?"

Ethan shook his head.

"No."

"Then start acting like you understand the consequences."

Ethan's voice broke.

"It was an accident."

His father looked at him coldly.

"Maybe today's accident was."

He paused.

"But what you did three years ago..."

"That was your choice."

Ethan lowered his head.

His father's voice became quieter.

"Your girlfriend died."

"You ran."

"You blamed Roman."

"You destroyed evidence."

"You made him disappear."

"And I covered it all."

Ethan remained on his knees.

Neither of them noticed...

that someone was listening.

A few meters away...

one of the club's employees quietly pushed a service cart through the corridor.

He wasn't really an employee.
The uniform was a disguise.
A small recording device was hidden beneath his collar.
He stopped near the private lounge.
The door was slightly open.
Every word carried through the gap.
He didn't move.
Didn't look inside.
He simply let the recording continue.
Inside...
Ethan's father continued speaking.
"How long do you think I can keep cleaning up after you?"
Ethan said nothing.
His head remained lowered.
The investigator quietly checked the recording device.
Everything was being captured.
Every confession.
Every mention of Roman.
Every detail about the cover-up.
He waited until the conversation ended.
Then quietly walked away.

Outside the club...
the investigator removed the hidden device.
He checked the recording.
The file was complete.
He immediately sent Roman a message.
We got it.
Roman's phone vibrated.
He opened the file.
He listened.
His expression slowly changed.
For months...
he had been searching for the truth.

Now...

the truth had finally spoken.

Roman stopped the recording.

He looked at Noah's recovered phone lying beside him.

Then at the recording.

His eyes hardened.

He typed one message.

Don't upload it yet. Keep the original safe.

A reply came.

Understood.

Roman placed the phone down.

He leaned back in his chair.

For the first time...

he knew exactly where the truth had been buried.

And now...

he only had to decide when to uncover it.